mentioned with unqualified disapprobation.’ Akbar ‘could not endure this unpleasant plain-speaking’ and Aziz was removed from his post as Governor of Gujarat and temporarily confined to his garden quarters in Agra.

With Aziz Koka and his intemperate criticisms dealt with, Akbar and the entire city of Fatehpur Sikri got ready to receive a visitor who brought with him all the nostalgia of the Timurid homeland—Mirza Sulaiman of Badakhshan*. After a long career spent skirmishing at the edge of the Hindustani empire in Badakhshan and Kabul, this old warlord from the time of Babur himself had been brought low by his own grandson who, in fine Timurid tradition, was planning to assassinate him. Keen to demonstrate Mughal resplendence to this scion of the Timurids, Akbar organized a magnificent display of Hindustani splendour. Five hundred elephants were lined up for 10 miles from the great gates of Fatehpur Sikri, ‘adorned with European velvet and embroidered fabric from Constantinople’ and ‘with chains of gold and of silver’. There were also fine, shimmying Arabian and Persian horses wearing golden saddles and, between every pair of elephants, there was a cart containing a velvet-eyed cheetah wearing a collar of gold and sitting on a carpet of embroidered gold. Raja Bhagwant Das, Governor of Lahore, accompanied the visitor to court and Akbar himself rode out several miles to greet the mirza. When they came face to face, Akbar dismounted and walked up to the mirza to embrace him and to prevent the old man from prostrating himself.

The palaces at Fatehpur Sikri were decorated with rich carpets, golden vessels, and tents of gold cloth, and when the young princes were presented to the elderly exiled ruler, Mirza Sulaiman was delighted and took them into his lap and kissed their cheeks. Old Chaghatai customs were hurriedly revived to impress the mirza. ‘They spread royal tables in the audience-hall,’ wrote Badauni, ‘and the officers of high grade gathered the soldiers together, and took to themselves the trouble of arranging the customary food.’ Qandahari noted that ‘bejewelled and golden plates, big bowls, made of Chinaware, sugar pots and countless other delicious dishes were served’. ‘But when the Mirza departed,’ Badauni sniffed contemptuously, ‘all these [revived customs] departed too.’ Clearly these old Turki–Chaghatai customs and foods were now present only as a memory, used as potent symbols when required, and then pragmatically set aside. Akbar’s changing nobility no longer justified the perfect remembrance of Chaghatai customs. This was